Working title

AI-Related Disclosure in Earnings Calls: Investor Attention, Valuation Effects, and Subsequent Reversal

Introduction

Amid the artificial intelligence (AI) stock rally so far, the concept of "AI washing" has gained increasing traction in both academic research and media coverage (Elhajjar & Itani, 2025; Anand et al., 2025; Sun et al., 2026; Milstead et al., 2025; Villegas, 2026). So far, Forbes has pointed out how some firms exaggerate their AI capabilities to attract attention, and how approximately only half of AI start-ups actually live up to their own description (Olson, 2019; Marr, 2024). Not stopping there, other major news outlets, namely Financial Times and Reuters, have reported increasing regulatory scrutiny and investor lawsuits related to misleading AI disclosures, possibly trying to artificially boost firms' stock price (Milstead et al., 2025; Villegas, 2026). Such articles suggest that AI washing as a disclosure strategy may have real financial market implications and possibly influence valuation beyond firms' underlying technological capabilities.

Corporate disclosure influences investor expectations and, consequently, asset prices. This, accompanied by heightened technological enthusiasm, proposes that firms with AI-related corporate communications can attract disproportionate investor attention and, consequently, boost their stock price. Although only a few papers have shed light on this area of interest, research in adjacent fields strongly supports this claim. For example, the literature on investor attention and market hype shows that technological narratives can influence stock prices beyond accounting fundamentals, particularly during periods of innovation-driven optimism.

As an attempt to capture firm-level AI disclosure in a dynamic setting, this study focuses on earnings call transcripts. Prior research demonstrates that linguistic features in earnings calls, such as tone, emphasis, and thematic intensity, predict stock returns and trading behavior well, making them a suitable medium through which to examine the market implications of AI disclosure.

Building on these insights, this paper investigates whether AI disclosure in earnings calls has economically meaningful consequences for firms. Specifically, it examines whether higher AI disclosure intensity is associated with subsequent stock price reactions, thereby assessing whether frequent AI references function as value-relevant signals or as drivers of market enthusiasm.

Two gaps remain in the current available literature that this paper aims to contribute to. First, most AI washing and AI disclosure studies rely on static disclosures (e.g., 10-K filings) or cross-sectional designs, leaving the dynamic evolution of AI narratives largely unexplored. Second, while the earnings-call literature documents the predictive power of tone and sentiment, it has paid limited attention to tech-specific narratives, particularly the surge in AI disclosure since 2020 and its role in recent stock price dynamics. By capturing how firms strategically communicate AI engagement over time, this paper contributes to and provides the current AI disclosure research base with a time-varying and tech-specific setting.

Literature review

AI washing

While AI had been advancing steadily since 2019, the introduction of generative AI in 2022 marked a turning point, triggering a pronounced stock rally during which firms associated with AI saw significant increases in market capitalization (Zorzi et al., 2025; Rawat, 2024). This surge in investor interest suggests that markets place growing weight on firms' strategic positioning in AI-related technologies. Nonetheless, this raises questions about the extent to which these valuations accurately reflect underlying firm fundamentals or firms' strategic disclosures to meet heightened investors' expectations.

A number of literature has picked up on this phenomenon and introduced AI washing as a strategic disclosure action, where firms overstate or ambiguously frame their AI capabilities to shape stakeholder perceptions without corresponding technological substance (Elhajjar & Itani, 2025). According to Anand et al. (2025), firms actively engage in AI washing as a signaling strategy, aiming to distinguish themselves from lower-type firms. Paradoxically, firms with higher true AI capability may even engage in greater exaggeration to inflate their positioning in investors' trusts.

Further empirical evidence suggests that AI disclosure can carry a nuanced and ambiguous signal, indicating both genuine technological investment and strategic over-signaling (Barrios et al., 2025). While certain AI disclosures are associated with real operational capabilities and future performance improvements, others appear to function primarily as signals intended for shaping investor expectations (Barrios et al., 2025; Sun et al., 2026). In particular, AI disclosure appears to be informative about future firm performance only when accompanied by underlying AI-related investments (Barrios et al., 2025). Firms lacking such investments may nevertheless use AI-related communication to influence investor expectations, driving short-term stock price increases despite uncertain fundamental improvements. This dual nature highlights the difficulty investors face in distinguishing AI adoption from strategic exaggeration based solely on disclosure intensity.

The limited empirical literature currently examining AI engagement and its economic implications does not fully account for this distinction between substantive AI adoption and strategic disclosure. For example, Zorzi et al. (2025) show that firms with higher generative AI exposure experienced stronger stock market performance during the recent AI rally. While their analysis does not specify whether this market response reflects genuine technological capability or disclosure intensity, the findings suggest that markets price AI-related exposure. This allows firms to leverage AI-related communication as a signaling strategy, potentially amplifying stock price reactions independent of underlying operational improvements.

Investors' Hype and Stock Price Association

Via AI washing, firms can ride the wave of AI frenzy and artificially boost their stock price. A substantial stream of finance and accounting research suggests that stock prices are, beyond firm fundamentals, driven by shifts in investor attention and narrative-driven "hype". When a topic becomes relevant for investors, whether through media coverage or broad market excitement, they can respond quickly and disproportionately and produce return patterns that are difficult to explain solely by fundamentals. Evidence from media settings supports this mechanism: increases in positive news flow are associated with stronger investor reactions and higher subsequent returns, while negative news tends to attract weaker or more delayed responses (Yuanyuan et al., 2023).

This attention-based mechanism becomes especially pronounced in periods of technological enthusiasm, where investors exhibit what some studies label "technophilia" - systematically positive reactions to disclosures about emerging technologies. Gao et al. (2022) document that short-term responses to technology disclosures are significantly positive but can reverse later, consistent with corrections once beliefs converge back toward fundamentals. Such patterns fit a broader behavioral interpretation of hype: optimistic beliefs and momentum can inflate prices during the "run-up" phase, while later disappointment or information revelation contributes to corrections. Johnson & Tellis (2005) extend on this and say that heuristics and biased extrapolation can amplify price increases in the short run, reinforcing "winner chasing" behavior that eventually becomes unstable and deeper reversals.

The hype mechanism in AI and technology is generally further reinforced by other precedents as well. For example, work on COVID-19 indicates that the hype of the topic, rather than sentiment, relates strongly to stock market returns (Biktimirov et al., 2021). Similarly, research on ESG greenwashing, the conceptual root for AI washing, finds that exaggerated sustainability claims are associated with elevated risk of future stock price crashes, aligning with the broader view that narrative inflation can produce mispricing that later unwinds (Zadeh & Hammami, 2025).

Taken together, these findings suggest that AI washing can operate as a narrative amplification mechanism. By intensifying investor attention, firms may experience short-term stock price appreciation, while inflated expectations increase the risk of subsequent reversal or crash. These establish the theoretical mechanism through which AI-related disclosure may influence stock prices and serve as the basis for the hypothesis development that follows.

Earnings Calls Narratives

Despite increasing attention to AI disclosure, evidence on how capital markets respond to AI-related strategic communication remains limited. This paper will therefore hinge on earnings calls to examine investor reactions to AI disclosure. Unlike 10-K filings or annual reports, which are highly regulated and standardized, earnings calls provide greater flexibility in narrative construction while still subjecting management to direct public questioning. Prior research suggested that the substantial length of 10-K filings is partly attributable to managerial discretion in responding to mandatory disclosure requirements, which may reduce interpretability and obscure economically relevant information (Cazier & Pfeiffer, 2015). Dyer et al. (2017) even addressed 10-K disclosure trends over time, which included an increase in length, redundancy, boilerplate, and stickiness, and a decrease in specificity, readability, and information richness. On the other hand, earnings calls are concise, interactive, and centered on forward-looking communication, which makes them a particularly suitable channel to observe strategic AI disclosure.

Importantly, earnings calls occur on known announcement dates and attract concentrated investor and analyst attention, allowing for the identification of immediate stock price reactions within clearly defined event windows (Rennekamp et al., 2022). This feature makes them especially appropriate for testing short-term valuation effects. Moreover, a substantial body of literature demonstrates that linguistic features in earnings calls are economically meaningful and predictive of firms' valuation (Medya et al., 2022; Francis & Vincent, 2002). This richness of textual information not only enables the capturing of AI disclosure but also allows the analysis to control for broader linguistic characteristics that have been proven to drive firms' valuation.

In contrast to the lack of AI disclosure literature, there has been a substantial body of past research on the topic of stock price movements around earnings calls. For example, stock prices are proven not to be driven solely by published accounting fundamentals, but also are strongly influenced by semantic and linguistic features of earnings calls transcripts, including tone, sentiment, and narrative richness (Medya et al., 2022;

Francis & Vincent, 2002). Prior research shows that linguistic tone in earnings calls accurately predicts abnormal returns beyond earnings surprises, with the Q&A section playing a particularly important role in conveying incremental information (Doran et al., 2010; Price et al., 2011). Moreover, sentiment extracted from earnings call transcripts predicts both short-term price movements and longer-term downside risk, suggesting that managerial tone reflects strategic disclosure choices rather than purely contemporaneous performance (Fu & Zhang, 2021; Jayaraman & Dennis, n.d.). Consequently, with the existing literature foundation, a transcript-based text analysis approach is strongly advocated to better understand market reactions to earnings calls.

Furthermore, more recent work established that earnings call narratives contain predictive information for future stock price movements, with text-based measures and narrative-based deep learning models outperforming traditional financial variables (Ma et al., 2020). Nonetheless, markets appear to underreact to such textual information from earnings calls, incorporating it only gradually into prices, resulting in predictable return patterns and post-announcement drift (Bodmeier & Hartzmark, 2017; Price et al., 2011).

With such a large body of literature emphasizing the importance of earnings call narratives on stock price, it may represent a channel through which AI washing manifests in financial markets. If investors respond to AI-related keywords regardless of realized firm performance, firms may strategically frame AI narratives to boost valuations or mask operational inefficiencies, especially with heightened investor enthusiasm for AI (Elhajjar & Itani, 2025; Zorzi et al., 2025). This possibility is consistent with research in the US banking sector, stating that AI disclosure intensity has increased over time and is shaped by governance incentives rather than purely informational motives (Alzeghoul & Alsharari, 2024). As a result, earnings calls are a suitable medium through which we can examine the market implications of AI disclosure.

Hypothesis Development

Research question

Synthesizing the literature reviewed above, AI washing can be understood as a strategic narrative choice through which firms emphasize or ambiguously frame their AI engagement to shape investor perceptions. In periods of heightened technological enthusiasm, such disclosures may attract disproportionate investor attention, triggering hype-driven reactions that temporarily decouple prices from underlying fundamentals. Prior research demonstrates that stock prices respond not only to accounting information but also to narrative cues and thematic emphasis, particularly during earnings calls where managerial discretion is high and forward-looking communication is concentrated. Consequently, AI-related disclosure in earnings calls provides a setting in which strategic AI positioning can translate into measurable market outcomes. If investors respond to AI intensity as a signal of growth and innovation, stock price reactions offer a direct observable channel through which the economic impact of AI disclosure, whether substantive or inflated, can be assessed. Consequently, this research aims to answer:

" *Does AI-related disclosure in earnings call transcripts influence firm valuation in the short-term, and do such effects persist or reverse over time*?"

AI Disclosure and Short-Term Valuation Effects

As aforementioned, prior research in attention-based finance suggested that hyped-up narratives can temporarily elevate firm valuations, even when underlying fundamentals do not fully justify such reactions (Gao et al., 2022). This is directly relevant for AI disclosure in corporate communication because AI is associated with productivity gains, scalability, and competitive advantage. References to AI may positively influence investor expectations about future cash flows regardless of operational improvements. Importantly, investors may rely on disclosure intensity as a biased cue, particularly when evaluating complex and uncertain technologies (Johnson & Tellis, 2005).

The literature on AI washing further suggests that firms may strategically emphasize AI-related initiatives in order to align themselves with prevailing technological narratives (Elhajjar & Itani, 2025; Anand et al., 2025). In such an environment, AI disclosure may amplify investor attention and generate favorable valuation responses in the short-term. Based on these arguments, the first hypothesis is formed regarding short-term impact of AI disclosure:

Hypothesis 1 (Short-term effect):

Greater AI-related disclosure is positively associated with short-term increases in firm valuation.

Long-Term Reversal To Fundamentals

While narrative-driven attention can inflate prices in the short run, behavioral finance research consistently documents that such effects may not be permanent (Gao et al., 2022). When investor expectations exceed realized performance, prices tend to adjust as information about fundamentals becomes clearer. Studies of technological hype, ESG-related overstatements, and other narrative-driven episodes show that initial price appreciation may be followed by correction once enthusiasm subsides or tangible outcomes fail to materialize (Biktimirov et al., 2021; Zadeh & Hammami, 2025).

If AI-related disclosure partly reflects strategic over-signaling rather than fully realized technological capability, the valuation effects driven by hype may be temporary. As firms subsequently report actual performance outcomes, investors are better able to assess whether AI-related initiatives translate into measurable operational improvements. In the absence of such improvements, prior optimism may unwind. Thus, the second hypothesis, while AI disclosure may generate short-term valuation gains, these gains are expected to diminish over time as prices revert toward levels more closely aligned with firm fundamentals.

Hypothesis 2 (Long-term reversal):

The positive association between AI-related disclosure and firm valuation weakens or reverses over the longer term.

Methodology

Data and Sample

This thesis constructs a firm-level panel dataset of publicly listed U.S. firms covering the period 2022-2024. This time window captures the period immediately preceding and following the introduction of generative AI technologies, most notably ChatGPT in late 2022, which marked a structural shift in investor attention toward AI-related themes. Beginning the sample in 2022 allows the analysis to include a pre-GenAI baseline, while the subsequent years reflect the heightened AI stock rally and intensified corporate AI-related disclosure. Focusing on this concentrated period enables the study to isolate variation in AI disclosure intensity during a time of pronounced market enthusiasm, while maintaining a manageable and internally consistent panel structure. Extending the sample further back to 2020 would introduce the substantial market disruption associated with the COVID-19 shock, a period characterized by extreme volatility and macroeconomic uncertainty that could confound the identification of AI-specific valuation effects.

The sample focuses on companies listed in the S&P100 index, thereby ensuring comparability in reporting standards, liquidity, and disclosure practices. The U.S. is selected as the region of interest due to the prominence of the recent AI-related equity market rally and the availability of standardized earnings call transcripts and financial data.

Quarterly earnings call transcripts are retrieved from the LSEG Research Data Platform. These transcripts are matched to firm identifiers and earnings announcement dates. Stock return data and accounting fundamentals are obtained from WRDS and/or LSEG and merged at the firm-quarter level.

To isolate discretionary AI-related disclosure from structural technological dependence, the baseline sample excludes firms operating in technology- and semiconductor-intensive industries. In these sectors, artificial intelligence constitutes a core operational input rather than a strategic narrative choice. Including such firms would risk conflating genuine production exposure with strategic communication. By focusing on non-AI-affiliated industries, the analysis better captures cross-sectional variation in AI disclosure that reflects managerial communication strategy rather than inherent technological necessity.

Textual Measures

As discussed above, earnings calls are used to exploit AI disclosure's valuation impact as because it not only combines managerial narrative discretion with immediate market scrutiny but also has rich linguistic features to capture and control for AI disclosure. Earnings call transcripts are preprocessed using standard text-cleaning procedures. A core AI disclosure intensity measure is constructed by counting AI-related keywords (e.g., *artificial intelligence*, *AI*, *machine learning*, *automation*), normalized by transcript length (mentions per 1,000 words). Multi-word expressions are identified via phrase matching, and short tokens such as "AI" are counted only when appearing as standalone words to avoid false positives. To avoid misidentifying general tech-savvy narratives, an extended set of AI-adjacent terms is incorporated in robustness analyses to ensure results are not driven by a set of AI keywords. This approach allows us to investigate whether valuation effects are driven by pure AI intensity or by more general technology-oriented, AI-adjacent discussions.

Accordingly, this paper introduces an AI dictionary including both core AI terms and a complementary set of AI-adjacent terms. It is constructed based on terminology identified in canonical AI literature, including Russell and Norvig's (2021) Artificial Intelligence: A Modern Approach, recent empirical studies examining AI narratives in corporate filings (e.g., Basnet et al., 2025), and formal policy taxonomies issued under the EU-U.S. Trade and Technology Council (2023). By cross-validating technical AI system terminology across academic and policy sources, the dictionary ensures conceptual alignment with formal definitions of AI while excluding irrelevant terms that could introduce measurement noise. The full term list in the dictionary is documented in Appendix 1.

As a validation step, a random sample of detected AI mentions is manually reviewed to assess match precision and refine the dictionary where necessary. This same text-based approach is also adopted and therefore validated by other preceding research (Ante & Saggu, 2025; Shiyyab et al., 2023). In parallel, sentiment and tone measures are extracted to capture the overall linguistic tone of managerial communication.

In addition, transcripts are segmented into the presentation section and the analyst Q&A section prior to textual analysis. This distinction reflects differences in managerial control and communication intent: prepared remarks are more likely to reflect strategic narrative framing, while Q&A responses are relatively spontaneous and shaped by analyst prompts. AI disclosure intensity and sentiment measures are therefore planned to be computed separately for each segment, allowing the analysis to distinguish between deliberate messages and reactive discussion of AI topics.

Research Design

Firm valuation impact is operationalized using abnormal stock returns around earnings announcement dates. Abnormal returns measure the deviation of a firm's realized return from its expected return given overall market movements. In efficient market frameworks, abnormal returns around information events reflect the market's reassessment of firm value in response to newly disclosed information. Because earnings calls provide forward-looking qualitative information beyond accounting numbers, abnormal returns around these events are widely used to capture investors' immediate valuation response to narrative disclosures. Thus, abnormal returns are not treated as the theoretical construct itself but as an empirical proxy for changes in a firm's valuation.

To test H1, the short-window event-study methodology is employed to estimate cumulative abnormal returns (CARs) around earnings announcement dates. Expected returns are estimated using a standard market model over a pre-event estimation window. Cumulative abnormal returns over short windows (e.g., [-1, +1]) capture immediate market reassessment. These abnormal returns are regressed on AI disclosure intensity, controlling for other factors such as overall tone, earnings surprises, and so on.

To test H2, the analysis examines longer-horizon stock performance following earnings announcements. Instead of focusing on short-window cumulative abnormal returns, the study evaluates firms' abnormal returns over subsequent quarters. These longer-term abnormal returns are regressed on AI disclosure intensity measured at the time of the earnings call, controlling for the same firm-level characteristics as in the short-term specification. Comparing the short- and long-term effects allows the study to assess whether the initial positive market reaction to AI-related disclosure weakens or reverses over time.

Expected Timeline

Month	Action points
March	Data collection & cleaning
April	Text analysis construction
May	Empirical analysis
June	Writing & revisions
July	Defense presentation preparations

Appendix

Appendix 1. AI-intensity & AI-adjacent dictionaries

Core Dictionary - AI intensity dictionary:

Topic	Keywords
Generic	*artificial intelligence, AI* (standalone token only), generative artificial intelligence, *generative AI, GenAI, AI-driven, AI-powered, AI-enabled, AI-based, intelligent automation, autonomous AI system, machine intelligence, AI agent*
Machine Learning	*machine learning, ML* (standalone token only)*, deep learning, neural network, neural networks, artificial neural network, ANN, convolutional neural network, CNN, recurrent neural network, RNN, supervised learning, unsupervised learning, semi-supervised learning, reinforcement learning, transfer learning, adversarial machine learning, generative adversarial network, GAN, expert system, adaptive algorithm*
Large Language Model	*large language model, large language models, LLM, LLMs, foundation model, foundation models, transformer model, generative model, text generation, language model, conversational AI,*
Named Technologies	*ChatGPT, GPT, GPT-3, GPT-4, OpenAI, Copilot, Bard, Gemini, Claude*
Computer vision	*computer vision, image recognition, object detection, facial recognition, optical character recognition, OCR, emotion recognition system*
NLP	*natural language processing, NLP (*standalone token only*), natural language understanding, NLU, language model, text generation, speech recognition, chatbot*

AI-adjacent dictionary:

Topic	Keywords
Automation &	*automation, automated, algorithm, algorithms, predictive analytics, advanced*

Analytics	*analytics, data analytics, data science, decision intelligence, intelligent systems, recommendation system, predictive analysis, profiling, adaptive learning, automated decision-making, bot*
Digital Transformation	*digital transformation, digitalization, digitization, intelligent systems, smart systems, industry 4.0, intelligent platform*
Robotics & Process Tech	*robotics, robotic process automation, RPA, autonomous systems*
Data & Infrastructure	*big data, data-driven, advanced computing, cloud-based intelligence, high-performance computing, AI infrastructure, structured data, unstructured data, input data*
Enterprise AI Integration	*AI integration, AI platform, AI capabilities, AI deployment, AI applications, AI strategy, AI solutions, AI initiative, AI roadmap*

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